

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN TAJIKISTAN

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the rivers, valleys, and water of Tajikistan — but this guide must begin with unusual honesty and unusual caution, because Tajikistan is among the hardest places in this series to oppose a project from within, and there is no community victory to point to. Tajikistan is a mountainous, landlocked, authoritarian state, ruled by one president since 1992, where independent civil society is rated "closed" — human-rights defenders and journalists are imprisoned and attacked, and most people, in the words of those who monitor the country, live in a climate of fear in which they would not dare to openly oppose a project. And the project that dominates the country's future is one of the largest in the world: the Rogun Dam, planned to be the tallest dam on earth, rising on the Vakhsh River, costing more than eight billion dollars, expected to displace tens of thousands of people, to flood a UNESCO World Heritage floodplain, and to reduce the flow of the Amu Darya — the great river of Central Asia — on which millions downstream in Afghanistan, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan depend. This guide will not pretend that a community inside Tajikistan can safely and openly stop such a project; it cannot.

The Tajik story teaches two things about opposing destructive projects here, and this guide states both plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the evidence, the coalition, and the pressure on the deciders — pressed together. The second is distinctly Tajik, and it is what gives this guide its real, if external, force.

Because Tajikistan's great project is a transboundary mega-dam financed by international development banks, the levers that matter are almost entirely outside the country: the financiers' safeguard policies and accountability mechanisms, the international law of shared rivers and the downstream states, the World Heritage status of what would be flooded, and the international coalitions that can carry affected people's concerns from safer ground. That combination — the banks' safeguards and complaint panels, the transboundary waters, UNESCO, and the international NGO coalitions — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it, because that is where the Rogun dam is actually being contested, and where a complaint to the World Bank's Inspection Panel has already been filed.

But the same story carries an honest warning this guide places first and takes with the utmost seriousness, because here the domestic danger is grave. **Opposition inside Tajikistan is dangerous, and open protest against the regime's signature project is close to impossible.** Civil-society space is closed; defenders and journalists are jailed; the resettlement of tens of thousands has already brought documented rights violations, with families given land but no houses and inadequate compensation, and little safe way to complain. The dam is the regime's prestige project, decades in the making, and the government is committed to it. The honest record is one of communities resettled with grievances unheard, an environmental assessment criticised as outdated and incomplete, and a project pressing ahead — not of anyone stopping it. This guide does not pretend the path is safe, easy, or likely to succeed from within. What it shows is how, in a closed state whose mega-project answers to international financiers and to the law of shared rivers, the fight can be carried to those external levers — by international coalitions, downstream communities, and the financiers' own mechanisms — while protecting people inside the country above all.

Most people affected inside Tajikistan cannot safely reach the levers that a bank-financed transboundary dam actually answers to — which is precisely why the international coalitions exist, and why this guide explains them. A resettled family, or a downstream community, may assume "the president has decided and the world is not watching," when in truth the world's development banks are voting on the financing, their accountability panels are hearing complaints, and international law governs the shared river. The gap between concerns unheard and concerns pressed is here, above all, a gap of reach — the reach to the international financing and transboundary channels where the project is genuinely vulnerable.

This guide shows what can actually be tried — given the Tajik system as it is, which is closed and dangerous from within, but whose mega-project is exposed from without. It is written for the person — inside Tajikistan or downstream, or an ally abroad — who wants to know whether anything can be done about a transboundary mega-dam in an authoritarian state. The answer is a heavily qualified yes: the external levers are real, they are already in use, and they can force safeguards, transboundary consultation, better resettlement, and international scrutiny — with the honest qualifiers that domestic opposition is dangerous, the regime is committed, and no one has stopped the dam. A note on who this guide is for, and on the spirit in which it must be used. It is for the international ally, the downstream community, or the affected person who understands that in Tajikistan the fight is waged from abroad and downstream, through the financing and the shared river, not in the streets of a closed state — that the work is documentation, complaint, coalition, and transboundary diplomacy, not domestic protest, which here is impossible and dangerous. That is not a lesser form of action but the only form that does not put people in prison, and the only one this guide can responsibly recommend. Anyone imagining that opposition here means a defiant public campaign inside the country should understand that no such campaign is possible, and that the real, reachable leverage lies entirely at the international financiers and the shared river. This guide is an honest map of that external leverage, and of how to reach it while keeping everyone inside safe.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to challenge a mega-dam, a mine, or another destructive project:

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION	(find the project, the harm, and the financiers)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION	(build the evidence -- harm and standards)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION	(organise -- carefully, and largely from abroad)
STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & INTERNATIONAL	(safeguards, waters, mechanisms)
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY	(raise it internationally)

These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The evidence of harm feeds the financiers' safeguards, the transboundary case, and the international media at once; the coalition organises, largely from abroad; a complaint to a bank's accountability panel or a report to UNESCO is both pressure and a spur to the next. The coalition that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives the best — if still external and uncertain — chance of forcing accountability on a project a closed state cannot be made to reconsider from within.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Tajikistan's — a closed domestic system, but a mega-project financed internationally and built on a shared river — put nearly all the leverage outside:

- **The financiers' safeguards.** The **development banks financing Rogun** are bound by safeguard policies and maintain **accountability mechanisms** — the World Bank Inspection Panel has already been petitioned.
- **The transboundary waters.** The **Vakhsh feeds the Amu Darya**, shared with downstream states; **international water law and downstream pressure** are a distinctive lever.
- **The World Heritage status.** The **Tugay Forests of Tigrovaya Balka**, a UNESCO World Heritage site the dam would harm, opens an international heritage lever.
- **The international coalitions.** **International river, human-rights, and bank-watchdog networks** carry affected people's concerns from safer ground.
- **The technical and dam-safety standards.** **Seismic and dam-safety concerns** in a highly seismic region are a lever of international scrutiny.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers will stop the dam, or that anyone can safely oppose it from within. There is **no community win**; civil-society space is **closed**; defenders are **jailed**; the regime is **committed**; and the dam is **pressing ahead**. This guide takes those limits with deadly seriousness — it states them first and throughout, and it puts the safety of people inside the country first — and shows how to use the real, distinctive, external tools this situation offers — the financiers' safeguards, the transboundary waters, UNESCO, and the international coalitions — to force accountability where a stop is unlikely and domestic opposition is dangerous.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see — and here you must also see clearly where the danger lies. Before you spend a single week, and before anyone inside the country takes a single risk, map who actually decides the project's fate, at which level, and where the leverage is real and the risk lowest. And map what would be lost and where the financiers' safeguards, the transboundary waters, the World Heritage status, and the international coalitions apply, because in Tajikistan a destructive mega-project cannot be stopped by domestic protest, which is dangerous and closed off, and is best contested at the international financing and transboundary level, where the project is genuinely exposed.

The Levels of Decision

A Tajik mega-project runs through several tracks, most of the decisive ones outside the country, and the task is to reach them.

The government. The **president and the state** drive the project as a national prestige goal and are, honestly, the hardest to move by any domestic means; opposition inside the country is closed and dangerous.

The international financiers. The **development banks financing the dam** — the World Bank and others — are bound by **safeguard policies** on resettlement, environment, and international waterways, and maintain **accountability mechanisms** a community or coalition can petition, as the World Bank Inspection Panel has been.

The transboundary waters and downstream states. The **shared river** — the Vakhsh feeding the Amu Darya — brings **international water law, the downstream states, and their communities** into play, a distinctive external lever.

The World Heritage and international bodies. UNESCO and the World Heritage status of what would be flooded, and other international bodies, apply pressure the domestic system cannot suppress.

The international coalitions. The international river, human-rights, and bank-watchdog networks are the vehicles that carry affected people's concerns to all of the above, from safer ground.

The Journey of a Project

A mega-dam moves from a national plan and a financing package, through environmental and social assessments and bank approvals, toward construction and resettlement — with the **financiers' safeguards, the transboundary case, the World Heritage status, and the international coalitions** able to intervene, above all at the **financing and assessment stages**, when the banks' safeguards and consultation requirements bite. **The financing decisions and the safeguard mechanisms are where the project is reachable**, and pressing them is the distinctive Tajik approach. The distinctive levers are the **financiers' safeguards and panels, the transboundary waters, UNESCO, and the international coalitions**. Find out exactly where the project and its financing stand, and, crucially, **what harm it would do upstream and downstream, which safeguards and international-water rules it breaches, and which accountability mechanisms apply**, because those are where a closed state's mega-project can still be contested.

Follow the Project, the River, and the Financiers

Behind a mega-dam stand the state and, decisively here, the international financiers and the shared river. Trace who decides, who funds it, and — importantly here — **what harm it would do to resettled communities, to the World Heritage floodplain, and to the downstream millions, which financier safeguards and international-water rules it breaches, and which accountability mechanisms and downstream states can be engaged**. Two questions unlock most Tajik efforts: **What harm would be done, upstream and down, and to what standards is the project bound?** and **Through which external channel — the financiers, the transboundary law, UNESCO, the coalitions — can that harm be pressed, safely?** The financiers' safeguards and the transboundary waters are, together, the heart of most such efforts here. Everything else in a Tajik effort ultimately serves these two: the documentation exists to prove a safeguard breach and a transboundary harm, the coalition exists to carry them safely to the banks and the downstream states, and the media exists to raise their cost before the international audiences those levers answer to. Keep the safeguards and the shared river at the center of every complaint, submission, and story, and the effort retains a clear, external, and reachable spine even when the domestic space is closed and dangerous and the regime immovable.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies that can check the deciders, because they are the levers. The **development banks and their accountability panels** — the World Bank Inspection Panel and the others; the **downstream states and the international law of shared rivers; UNESCO and the World Heritage Committee**; the **international river and bank-watchdog coalitions** — the river networks, the bank-monitoring groups, the human-rights-in-development coalitions; and **international human-rights bodies** documenting the resettlement. In Tajikistan, the **financiers' safeguards, the transboundary waters, UNESCO, and the international coalitions** are the most distinctive levers, and nearly all of them lie outside the closed domestic system. Each is a separate front, and a project shown to breach the financiers' safeguards, harm a shared river and a World Heritage site, and resettle tens of thousands without adequate process can be pressed at the international points where it is exposed — as the Inspection Panel complaint and the campaigns to the banks attest — though, honestly, the regime is committed and the dam presses ahead,

and this guide will keep saying so, and keep insisting on safety.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort — or before anyone inside the country takes any risk — calibrate honestly, and here that means acknowledging that stopping the dam is unlikely, that domestic opposition is dangerous, and that the strongest levers are external and slow. These figures are **directional and deliberately sober** — patterns drawn from how bank-financed mega-projects have been contested, not a controlled study, and not a promise. The decisive variables are whether the coalition can **document harm against the financiers' safeguards and international-water rules**, whether it can **reach the accountability mechanisms and downstream states** the closed domestic system cannot, and whether it can **protect the people inside**. Where the harm is provable and the financing is international, the external levers are real; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that civil-society space is closed, defenders are jailed, the regime is committed, and the dam is a national prestige project.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5–15%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Harm-against-safeguards case	25–45%	weeks–months	low	The breach, shown to those who can act
Financiers' accountability mechanism	30–50%	months–years	low–moderate	An investigation; safeguards; leverage
Transboundary / downstream-state route	25–45%	months–years	low	International-water pressure and scrutiny
UNESCO / World Heritage route	25–40%	months–years	low	Heritage pressure on the flooded site
International coalition & media	30–50%	ongoing	low	Scrutiny the closed system cannot silence
All steps (bank-financed, external)	30–50%	months–years	moderate	Safeguards, mitigation, delay, rarely a stop
Domestic protest alone	2–10%	days–weeks	grave risk	Repression; effectively impossible

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Tajikistan's real strengths are entirely **external**: the **financiers' safeguards and panels**, the **transboundary waters**, **UNESCO**, and the **international coalitions**. Its constraints are specific, honest, and heavy: civil-society space is **closed**, defenders are **jailed**, the regime is **committed**, and the dam is a **prestige project** — and there is **no community win** to build on, and no safe domestic path.

*A note on cost and risk: the external levers here — a documented case, a complaint to a bank's panel, a submission on the shared river, a report to UNESCO — cost mainly knowledge and persistence, and, crucially, are pursued largely from abroad, away from the danger inside. The scarce resources are **the international coalitions' reach and the safe channelling of affected people's testimony** — not funds. Reaching the financiers and the transboundary bodies is worth far more here*

the transboundary bodies is worth far more here, in the end, than any domestic action, and is the only way that does not put people inside at grave risk. This is the plainest and most important calculation in the guide: a channel that reaches the international financiers or the downstream states, and does so from safe ground abroad, is worth incomparably more than any domestic gesture — which in a closed state is not merely futile but a route to prison. Because the decisive levers are the banks' safeguards, the law of shared rivers, and international scrutiny, and because these are reached through documentation, complaints, and coalitions rather than through numbers or visible defiance, a small, well-organised external effort can wield real influence without exposing a single person inside. The expensive and dangerous parts of a normal campaign — the mass mobilisation, the public confrontation — are not merely unavailable here but actively harmful; the effective parts are the quiet, documented, external ones that a coalition can conduct from safety.

Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (safeguards, mitigation, scrutiny, or -- rarely -- a halt)

PROVABLE HARM + SAFEGUARDS + TRANSBOUNDARY + COALITIONS:

All steps combined:	■■■■■■■■■■	30-50%
Financiers' mechanism:	■■■■■■■■■■	30-50%
International coalition:	■■■■■■■■■■	30-50%
Transboundary route:	■■■■■■■■■■	25-45%
Single step:	■■	5-50%

DOMESTIC-ONLY, IN A CLOSED STATE -- effectively impossible:

All steps combined:	■■■■	10-20%
Safeguards / mitigation:	■■■■■■■■■■	sometimes achievable
The record / the case made:	■■■■■■■■■■	far more reliable than a stop
Domestic protest alone:	■	2-10% and dangerous

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Tajikistan are the **external** ones — the financiers' safeguards and panels, the transboundary route, UNESCO, and the international coalitions — while domestic protest is both perilous and effectively impossible. The reach of the financiers' mechanisms shows the ceiling: a bank-financed project can be investigated and pressed from abroad, its safeguards enforced, its worst harms mitigated. The closed civil-society space and the jailed defenders show the honest, grim floor: inside Tajikistan, there is no safe way to oppose the dam at all. Most efforts will aim not at a stop — the regime is committed — but at forcing safeguard compliance, better resettlement, transboundary consultation, and international scrutiny. The honest lesson is that the external levers are real and already in use — able to force accountability, safeguards, mitigation, and scrutiny, and conceivably to delay or reshape the project — but that a stop is unlikely, and domestic opposition is dangerous.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

- 1. The harm-against-safeguards case** — Tajikistan's foundation; the harm measured against the financiers' binding safeguards and international-water rules.
- 2. The financiers' accountability mechanisms** — the distinctive lever; the banks' complaint panels, already petitioned over Rogun.
- 3. The transboundary and UNESCO routes** — the shared-river and World Heritage leverage the closed state cannot suppress.
- 4. The international coalitions and media** — the reach and the scrutiny that carry it all from safer ground.
- 5. The domestic testimony, safely gathered** — the affected people's evidence, channelled abroad without exposing them.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest, sobering patterns recur. **The external levers are the real ones** — the Rogun dam is contested at the banks and the transboundary bodies, not in the streets of Dushanbe. the Rogun dam is contested at the banks and the transboundary bodies, and by international coalitions abroad, not in the streets of Dushanbe, where no such contest is possible. **Domestic opposition is closed and dangerous** — defenders are jailed and people live in fear. **The financiers' safeguards can bite** — the Inspection Panel has been petitioned, consultations demanded, assessments criticised. **Accountability and mitigation are likelier than a stop** — safeguards and better resettlement can sometimes be forced even as the dam proceeds. **There is no community win** — none, honestly, to point to. The through-line: **document the harm, upstream and down, against the financiers' safeguards and international-water rules; reach the banks' mechanisms, the transboundary bodies, UNESCO, and the international coalitions — the closed state cannot suppress them; protect the people inside — because a coalition that does can force safeguards, mitigation, and scrutiny, and conceivably delay or reshape a mega-dam, while being honest that a stop is unlikely, domestic opposition is dangerous, and there is no precedent of a community win.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact project and harm that govern the threat — and the leverage that exists, which here is almost entirely external: the financiers, the shared river, and the international bodies. Vague concern goes nowhere, and domestic protest is dangerous and closed off; an effort aimed at "the mega-dam that would displace tens of thousands, flood a World Heritage floodplain, and cut the shared river's flow to millions downstream — financed by development banks bound by safeguards they may be breaching, and already before the World Bank's Inspection Panel" is a strategic, external, and safer effort — the kind that can actually reach the points where the project is exposed. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

- 1. What harm would the project do — upstream and downstream?** This is the first question here. What harm to resettled communities, to the World Heritage floodplain and its endangered species, and to the downstream millions who depend on the shared river — as the Rogun dam threatens all three.
- 2. Who finances it, and to what safeguards?** Which development banks finance it, and which safeguard policies — on resettlement, environment, and international waterways — bind them, the distinctive Tajik question.
- 3. Is it a shared river, and who is downstream?** Does the project affect a transboundary river and downstream states and communities, opening the international-water and downstream lever.
- 4. Which external mechanisms apply?** Which of the financiers' accountability panels, UNESCO, the international-water bodies, and the international coalitions can be engaged — as the Inspection Panel has been.
- 5. How can this be done safely?** Given the closed, dangerous domestic space, how can the effort proceed without exposing people inside — through international coalitions, downstream channels, and the financiers' mechanisms, not domestic protest.

A Worked Example

Suppose a mega-dam will displace tens of thousands, flood a protected floodplain, and cut a shared river's flow downstream, its assessment criticised as outdated, its financing international.

Working the five questions: **what harm, upstream and down? Who finances it, to what safeguards? Is it a shared river? Which external mechanisms apply?** And, always, **how can this be done safely?** The deciders are the state and, decisively, the financiers, with the safeguards, the transboundary law, UNESCO, and the coalitions as the pressure points.

Within a season the effort has moved from "the president has decided and no one can object" to a strategy that reaches where the project is exposed: document the harm against the safeguards; petition the financiers' accountability panel; engage the transboundary bodies and downstream states; and enlist the international coalitions and UNESCO — all while protecting people inside. That is a strategic, external, safety-first effort suited to Tajikistan — not a domestic protest the regime would crush. Notice what the five questions accomplish: they convert a raw sense of helplessness — the president has decided, the dam will be built, and no one inside dares object — into a set of specific, answerable, and entirely external targets, each attached to a lever beyond the regime's reach and away from the danger inside. The harm becomes documentable evidence, much of it already published. The financing becomes named safeguards to invoke before accountability panels. The shared river becomes a matter of international water law and downstream diplomacy. The channels become specific external bodies to petition. And the safety question, asked at every step, keeps the effort from ever tipping into the exposed domestic action that would put people in prison. That translation — from a closed, hopeless domestic grievance into a strategic, protected, offshore campaign — is the first and most important thing a Tajik effort must do, because it moves the fight from ground where opposition is impossible and dangerous to ground where the project is genuinely exposed and people are safe.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, where the strongest case is made to international financiers and transboundary bodies against defined standards, sound, standard-referenced evidence is decisive. A bank's accountability panel, a downstream government, a UNESCO committee, and an international coalition all move on evidence measured against rules — and in Tajikistan, a clear record of the harm, and of how it breaches the safeguards and the international-water rules the project is bound to, is precisely what an effort turns into external leverage, so build it well, and safely. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Financiers, and the Safeguards

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **project, its cost and scale, the financing banks, and the assessments** — the environmental and social impact assessment, the techno-economic study — obtaining them where public, as the World Bank has published Rogun's. Establish which **safeguard policies bind the financiers** — on resettlement, environment, and international waterways — for these are the rules against which harm becomes an actionable breach. Establish the deciders, the financiers, and the safeguards precisely, because the distinctive case here is not merely that the dam does harm, but that it does harm in breach of the safeguards its own financiers are bound to uphold — as complaints over Rogun's outdated assessment and absent consultations allege.

Layer 2: The Harm — Upstream, at the Site, and Downstream

Document the harm, thoroughly and safely. Establish the **resettlement harm** — the tens of thousands displaced, given land but not houses, inadequately compensated, cut off from farming and livestock, as human-rights investigators have documented. Establish the **environmental harm** — the flooded World Heritage floodplain, the endangered endemic species, the altered river. And establish the **downstream harm** — the reduced flow of the shared river, the threat to the water security of millions in the downstream states and the stressed river basin. Gather it carefully, protecting those inside who provide it, in a state that jails dissent. Photographs, the banks' own disclosure documents, scientific studies, and human-rights reports make the harm undeniable — and, measured against the safeguards and international-water rules, actionable.

Layer 3: The Harm, the Standards, the Channel, and Safety

Finally, document the case and the plan. Does the **harm** breach the **financiers' safeguards** and the **international-water rules**? Does it threaten a **World Heritage site**? Which **channel** — the banks' panels, the transboundary bodies, UNESCO, the coalitions — is open, and what does it require? And, always and above all, **how can this be done safely**, protecting people inside from a regime that jails opposition? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case that can be pressed at the international points where a bank-financed transboundary dam is exposed. This is the layer that most often decides what can be decided here, because a documented harm, a demonstrable breach of binding safeguards and international-water rules, an open external channel, and a safe way to use it are exactly what give this fight leverage the closed domestic system denies it. Build it well, and the project's own financiers, safeguards, and shared river become the levers against it. One practical note on building this layer: the whole external strategy depends on identifying, precisely and early, the exact safeguards and international-water rules the project is bound to, because a general complaint of harm carries little weight while a documented breach of a named, binding safeguard is actionable before an accountability panel. Which lender's resettlement policy requires replacement housing and livelihood restoration that the project has not provided? Which environmental safeguard requires a current, independent impact assessment that the project's outdated study fails to meet? Which operational rule on international waterways requires notification of and consultation with downstream riparian states that the project has skipped? Establish these specific, binding rules first, ideally with the help of a coalition experienced in bank complaints, and then measure the project's conduct against each, so that the case is not 'this dam is harmful' but 'this dam breaches this named safeguard in this documented way.' That precision is what transforms a grievance a closed regime can ignore into a complaint an international accountability mechanism must consider.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists. Here is where the material tends to live in a Tajik effort, and how to get it — with the **harm**, the **safeguards and international-water rules**, and the **external mechanisms** at the center, and with the safety of people inside a constant concern. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Project, Financing, and Safeguard Record

Start with the project itself. **Project plans, costs, and the assessments** — the environmental and social impact assessment, the techno-economic study — are, for a bank-financed project, often public; the World Bank has published Rogun's, and the banks' disclosure requirements are themselves a lever. Identify the **financing banks** — the World Bank and the others in the financing scheme — and the **safeguard policies** binding them, which are public and are the rules your case will invoke. Establish exactly **what the project**

is, who finances it, and to what safeguards it is bound, because those safeguards are the fight's distinctive leverage.

The Harm Evidence — Gathered Safely

This is the heart of the file, and it must be gathered with the greatest care for people inside. Document the **resettlement harm** — the displaced families, the missing houses, the inadequate compensation, the lost land — drawing on **human-rights investigators' reports**, which have documented exactly this at Rogun, so that testimony need not always be gathered anew at fresh risk. Document the **environmental harm** — the World Heritage floodplain, the endangered species — from **scientific studies and the assessments themselves**. And document the **downstream harm** — the reduced river flow, the threat to millions — from **hydrological studies and the complaints already filed**. Protect anyone inside who provides evidence, and lean on already-published documentation to avoid fresh risk. Credible, standard-referenced harm evidence, much of it already gathered by international bodies, is the file's most powerful content.

The Safeguards, Waters, and Heritage Record

Document the rules, the river, and the site, because these are the distinctive Tajik levers. Gather the **safeguard policies** on resettlement, environment, and international waterways, and how the project breaches them. Gather the facts of the **shared river** — that the Vakhsh feeds the Amu Darya, on which downstream states and millions depend — and the **international-water rules** the project's assessment is accused of ignoring. And document the **World Heritage status** of the floodplain the dam would harm. A case that shows harm in breach of binding safeguards, harm to a shared river assessed without proper transboundary consultation, and harm to a World Heritage site holds leverage the closed domestic system cannot match.

The Mechanisms and Coalitions

Identify the external channels and allies. The **financiers' accountability mechanisms** — the World Bank Inspection Panel and the other banks' complaint offices — are the distinctive channel, already engaged over Rogun. The **transboundary and international-water bodies**, and the **downstream states**, are a further channel. **UNESCO and the World Heritage Committee** address the flooded site. And the **international coalitions** — the river networks, the bank-watchdog groups, the human-rights-in-development coalitions — are the vehicles that carry it all from safer ground. Map which apply, because in Tajikistan these external channels are essentially the only ones, and are far safer than any domestic action.

The People — and Their Protection

Finally, map the human terrain, with the safety of those inside foremost. Who is affected — the resettled families, the downstream communities? Who are the **international coalitions, the human-rights investigators, the downstream civil society, and the sympathetic experts** who can act from safer ground? And, crucially, **how are people inside protected** — from a regime that jails dissent and monitors defenders? A Tajik effort is advanced not by any domestic movement, which is closed and dangerous, but by international coalitions and downstream allies carrying affected people's concerns to the financiers and the transboundary bodies — so map that external coalition, and the protection of everyone inside, above all.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Evidence does not move deciders by itself — but here, more than almost anywhere in this series, "local opposition" must be reconceived, because inside Tajikistan open opposition is closed off and dangerous,

and the meaningful organising happens largely abroad and downstream. What moves the deciders here is not a domestic demonstration, which is effectively impossible and perilous, but an international coalition carrying the documented concerns of affected people to the financiers and the transboundary bodies. Tajikistan offers essentially no safe space for open domestic opposition; the task is to channel affected people's stake, safely, into an external effort that repression cannot reach.

Why the Community Is Decisive — and Why It Must Act From Safer Ground

An international accountability panel or a downstream government can act on the documented concerns of affected communities; but inside a closed state, those communities cannot safely voice them. The affected people supply what the effort runs on: the testimony of resettlement, the evidence of harm, the legitimacy that makes an international complaint credible. But in Tajikistan this must be channelled through safer ground — international coalitions, downstream civil society, human-rights investigators — rather than through domestic protest, which the regime would crush. **The affected community is the effort's moral heart — but its voice is best carried by international coalitions from safer ground, never through exposed domestic opposition that would put people in prison.** This is the hardest reconception in the guide, and it must be understood not as abandoning the affected people but as protecting them while still carrying their cause. In an open society, the resettled families would testify at hearings, petition their government, and march; in Tajikistan, any of that could mean prison. The role of the international coalition is precisely to be the voice that the affected cannot safely be — to take their documented situation, gathered with care and consent and full protection of identities, and press it before the financiers, the downstream states, and the world, where the affected themselves cannot safely tread. This is not ventriloquism but shelter: the affected people's stake and testimony remain the moral and evidentiary heart of the case, but the exposure and the risk are borne by those abroad who can bear them safely. A coalition that understands this keeps the affected people at the centre of the cause while keeping them out of the reach of the regime.

Finding the Affected Community — Inside and Downstream

Begin with those the project touches most, on both sides of the border: the **resettled families inside Tajikistan**, whose displacement is documented, and the **downstream communities** in the neighbouring states, whose water the dam would reduce. The downstream communities, in states with their own constraints but outside the immediate reach of Tajikistan's regime, may sometimes voice concerns more safely, and their stake in the shared river is a powerful, legitimate part of the case. Name the shared stake — **our homes, our river, our water, across the whole basin** — and carry it, for safety, through international and downstream channels rather than domestic protest. The transboundary framing is not only a legal lever but a genuine widening of the affected community, and it is one of the distinctive features of a shared-river fight. The people harmed by a mega-dam are not only those flooded out or resettled upstream, but the millions downstream — farmers, fishers, city-dwellers in the neighbouring states — whose water the dam would reduce. This vastly enlarges the constituency with a legitimate stake in the project, and brings in downstream communities and even whole governments who lie outside the immediate reach of the upstream regime and can sometimes voice concerns more freely. A fight that frames itself around the whole river basin, rather than only the upstream site, both strengthens its moral and legal case and draws in allies the upstream regime cannot silence — which is precisely why the transboundary dimension is so central to contesting a mega-dam.

Coalition-Building From Abroad

A community allied is stronger than a community alone, and in Tajikistan the coalition is built largely abroad. Reach to the **international river networks, the bank-watchdog groups, and the**

human-rights-in-development coalitions already engaged on Rogun; the **human-rights investigators** documenting the resettlement; the **downstream civil society** in the neighbouring states; and **sympathetic experts** on dams, water, and safeguards. These external allies can carry the affected people's case to the financiers, the transboundary bodies, and UNESCO from ground the Tajik regime cannot reach. Frame the coalition around the documented harm and the breached standards, and lean entirely on the external allies to press what no one inside can safely press.

Sustaining a Careful, External Effort

Tajik efforts are external, slow, and constrained, and sustaining them means sustaining both persistence and the safety of those inside. Keep the coalition **organised, informed, and protective of everyone in the country**; mark the external steps — a complaint filed, a bank consultation forced, a downstream government engaged, a UNESCO concern raised. And keep it **safe** — never expose people inside to the regime, and rely on published documentation and downstream and international voices wherever possible. The effort that lasts is the one that stays organised abroad, protective of those inside, and focused on the external financing and transboundary levers that repression cannot reach. Sustaining such an effort demands a particular temperament, because its rewards are external, slow, and often invisible on the ground inside Tajikistan, while its central discipline — protecting people inside — is unyielding. There will rarely be a visible domestic victory; there will be, instead, a complaint accepted by a bank's panel, a financing decision delayed for a fuller assessment, a downstream government raising the matter, a resettlement plan improved under international pressure. A coalition that measures itself only by whether the dam stops will despair, because a committed regime makes a stop unlikely; one that values the accumulation of safeguard compliance, better resettlement, transboundary consultation, and international scrutiny — while never once exposing a person inside — can endure, and can raise the bar for the next mega-project as well. Endurance here is patient, external, protective persistence.

STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & INTERNATIONAL CHALLENGES — THE FINANCIERS' SAFEGUARDS, THE TRANSBOUNDARY WATERS, AND THE ACCOUNTABILITY MECHANISMS

This is where a Tajik effort is realistically waged — not through domestic protest, which is closed and dangerous, nor through captured domestic courts, but through the **financiers' safeguards, the international law of shared rivers, and the banks' accountability mechanisms** to which a bank-financed transboundary dam answers. Here the distinctive Tajik levers are entirely external, and the coalition's task is to reach them.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth. The domestic levers are **effectively absent**: civil society is closed, courts are captured, and protest is dangerous. The **external levers are stronger but slow and uncertain**: the financiers' mechanisms can investigate and press but rarely stop a project their boards have approved; the transboundary and UNESCO routes apply pressure but move slowly; and the regime is committed. What these levers realistically achieve is **safeguard compliance, better resettlement, transboundary consultation, mitigation, delay, and scrutiny** — not usually a stop, and never at the cost of safety inside. Enter this front clear-eyed and safety-first: the financiers' safeguards, the transboundary waters, and the accountability mechanisms are Tajikistan's distinctive levers, strongest when the **harm is provable and the breach of safeguards and international-water rules is clear** — but the realistic outcome is accountability, not a stop.

The Financiers' Safeguards and Mechanisms

The first and most distinctive front is the financing. A bank-financed project is bound to **safeguard policies** on resettlement, environment, and international waterways, and its financiers maintain **independent accountability mechanisms** — the World Bank Inspection Panel and the others' complaint offices — to which affected communities and their representatives can file. Establish the safeguards, document the breach — the inadequate resettlement, the outdated assessment, the absent transboundary consultation, as complaints over Rogun allege — and **file with the mechanism**, which can trigger investigation and pressure for compliance and mitigation. Press, too, the **financing decisions themselves**, where the banks' boards vote and public consultations are held, since that is the moment of maximum leverage. This front is safest and strongest, because it is pursued abroad, through the banks' own rules.

The Transboundary Waters

The second and distinctive front is the shared river. Because the Vakhsh feeds the Amu Darya, on which **downstream states and millions of people** depend, the project engages the **international law of shared rivers and the financiers' own operational rules on international waterways** — rules the project's assessment is accused of ignoring by failing to properly assess transboundary impacts or consult riparian communities. Engage the **downstream states and their civil society**, and press the transboundary-consultation requirement, because harm to a shared river is a matter of international law and diplomacy that a single upstream regime cannot foreclose. This transboundary lever is the one that most distinguishes a mega-dam fight, and it brings whole downstream nations into the case. Take the time to understand how the financiers' own rules on international waterways work, because they are unusually powerful in a shared-river fight. Most development banks have a specific operational policy governing projects on international waterways, which typically requires the borrower to notify the other riparian states and to assess transboundary impacts before the bank will proceed — a requirement that exists precisely because a dam on a shared river affects nations that did not choose it. Where a project's assessment is accused of denying or understating downstream flow reductions, or of skipping genuine transboundary consultation, that is not merely a scientific dispute but a potential breach of the financiers' own binding waterways policy — one that downstream states and coalitions can raise directly with the banks. This makes the transboundary dimension not a vague appeal to fairness but a concrete, actionable lever grounded in the financiers' own rules.

UNESCO and the Coalitions

The third front is heritage and reach. **UNESCO and the World Heritage Committee** can address harm to the flooded World Heritage floodplain, applying international heritage pressure. And the **international coalitions** — the river networks, the bank watchdogs, the human-rights-in-development groups — are the vehicles that file the complaints, engage the banks and downstream states, brief UNESCO, and carry the affected people's concerns from safer ground, as they have throughout the Rogun campaign. Pursued from abroad, through the banks' rules, the law of shared rivers, the World Heritage system, and the international coalitions, these fronts are how a closed state's mega-dam is contested — and contested without exposing people inside to a regime that jails dissent. It is worth understanding why these three external fronts reinforce one another, because their combination is the heart of contesting a bank-financed transboundary mega-dam. The financiers' safeguards supply the binding rules and the accountability panels — the sharpest and most direct lever, because the banks can attach conditions, demand fuller assessments, or withhold funds. The transboundary waters supply the international-law dimension and the downstream states, who bring diplomatic weight and their own standing that no upstream community possesses. And UNESCO and the coalitions supply the heritage pressure and the reach that carry it all to a global audience.

Each alone is limited: the banks may finance despite objections, the downstream states may prioritise other relations, UNESCO moves slowly. But woven together — a safeguard breach lodged with the panel, the transboundary harm raised by downstream states and under international water law, the World Heritage threat before UNESCO, all amplified by international coalitions — they form a web of external accountability that a bank-financed transboundary dam cannot easily escape, and that reaches entirely over the head of the closed domestic system.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each decider in the language that moves them — and here, above all, in the language of safeguards and international water, and from the safety of external forums. The same file of harm and breach becomes different arguments for a bank's accountability panel, a downstream government, a UNESCO committee, and the international coalitions. Translate deliberately, and always protecting those inside.

For the Financiers' Mechanisms

The financiers' complaint panels respond to **the safeguard policies and the evidence of breach**. Frame the harm precisely as a failure to meet a named safeguard: the resettlement without adequate housing or compensation, the outdated environmental assessment, the absent transboundary consultation, the international-waterways rule ignored. Give them the documented breach and ask for investigation and compliance. Make it easy to act within their mandate: *here is the safeguard, here is the harm, here is the breach*. This is the argument that reaches furthest, and safest, here.

For the Downstream States and Water Bodies

Downstream governments and international-water bodies respond to **threats to shared water**. Frame the harm as a reduction of the shared river's flow, assessed without proper transboundary consultation, threatening the water security of millions downstream. A downstream state has its own standing and its own interest in the shared river, and can press concerns an upstream community cannot. Give them the hydrological evidence and the international-water rules, so the case becomes a matter of interstate concern and law.

For UNESCO and International Bodies

UNESCO and international bodies respond to **harm to what they protect**. Frame harm to the flooded floodplain as a threat to a World Heritage site and its endangered endemic species, of global significance. Their concern applies international heritage pressure the domestic system cannot suppress. Give them the documented harm to the site's values.

For the Coalitions and the World

The international coalitions and public respond to **a clear, documented injustice and a global stake**. Translate the file into a story that is true and safe to tell from abroad: a prestige mega-dam displacing tens of thousands, flooding a world heritage floodplain, and cutting the water of millions downstream — financed by banks bound by safeguards they may be breaching. Keep it scrupulously accurate; before banks, states, and international bodies, overstatement discredits, and careless exposure of people inside endangers them — so protect them in every telling.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, and never expose people inside needlessly. Your credibility is your greatest asset before an accountability panel and a downstream government, and the safety of people inside Tajikistan is more important than any argument. State the harm precisely, measure it against the safeguards and international-water rules accurately, and pursue it through the safest external channel. A coalition that is precise, credible, and protective — especially of the safeguards and the people — is far harder to dismiss than one that overreaches, and far safer than one that exposes anyone inside.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into pressure — but in Tajikistan, that pressure works only when it reaches an international audience, and domestic media is state-controlled and any domestic voice is dangerous. The story — a prestige mega-dam harming people, a shared river, and a world heritage site in breach of its financiers' safeguards — is one that travels, and travels only, abroad.

Why Media Matters — Only Abroad

The financiers, the downstream states, and a government conscious of its international standing behave differently when harm is visible internationally. Media does three things here: it **informs and pressures the financiers and the downstream and international publics**, it **raises the reputational cost** to the banks and the government, and it **draws the international attention** that domestic repression cannot silence. Because the domestic press is state-controlled and domestic voices are in danger, international media — and the coverage that international coalitions generate — is essentially the only media lever, and it has been central to the Rogun campaign. A harm made visible to the banks' home publics and the downstream nations is one the financiers cannot easily ignore. This is why the international and downstream press deserve particular emphasis in a Tajik effort. A development bank finances a mega-dam largely out of sight of its own member publics and the taxpayers who ultimately back it; that invisibility is part of what allows a flawed project to proceed. Bringing a documented, credible account of the harm to the banks' home audiences — to the press and the parliaments of the member states, to the downstream nations whose water is at stake — collapses the distance that shielded the decision, and forces the financiers to answer, before their own constituencies, for a project they preferred to keep technical and remote. Cultivate these international and downstream outlets with accuracy and care, and with unwavering protection of anyone inside, because their reach turns a remote Central Asian dam into a matter the financiers' own publics are watching.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the scale of the harm and the broken safeguard. The strongest frame is concrete and internationally legible: *the world's tallest planned dam would displace tens of thousands, flood a world heritage floodplain, and cut the water of millions downstream — financed by development banks bound by safeguards they may be breaching*. Put the human and environmental and downstream harm first, and the breach of the financiers' safeguards close behind, because that breach engages the international audience and the accountability bodies. Keep it scrupulously accurate; before banks and international media, overstatement is caught and discredits the case.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience, and to safety. **International media and the banks' home-country press** for the reputational and accountability pressure that reaches furthest; **international NGO and coalition networks** for amplification and for the protection they afford; **downstream-state media** for the

transboundary dimension; and **domestic media essentially not at all**, given its state control and the danger to any domestic voice. Because Tajikistan's mega-dam answers abroad, to financiers and downstream nations, the international and downstream channels are the only ones that matter — and the only safe ones.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, credible, and protective — the goal is international accountability, not a domestic story that would endanger people. Protect individuals inside absolutely; never name or expose a person inside Tajikistan who could be targeted, and rely on international coalitions, downstream voices, and already-published documentation to carry the story. Handle the banks, the government, and the downstream states factually, because credibility before international bodies depends on it. And sustain the effort patiently, because international accountability moves slowly. Above all, let the documented harm and the breached safeguards, carried by international coalitions to a global audience, do the work — because that is where a Tajik effort is both most effective and least dangerous.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real project, the real harm, and the real safeguards, keep it factual, and protect anyone inside. Here precision against standards, and safety, matter more than force. Where an author or signatory could be endangered, use an international coalition as the sender.

8A: Requesting Information and the Assessments

Subject: Request for project documents — [project], safeguards and assessments

To [bank / project authority],

We write regarding [project]. To engage constructively, we request the **environmental and social impact assessment**, the **resettlement plan**, the **techno-economic and dam-safety studies**, and the **safeguard policies and international-waterways documentation** applicable to the project's financing. We wish to assess the project's compliance with the safeguards to which its financing is committed.

We would be grateful for a response by [date].

Respectfully,

[International coalition / representative, contact]

8B: Complaint to a Financier's Accountability Mechanism

Subject: Complaint regarding [project] — breach of safeguard policies

To the [Inspection Panel / accountability mechanism],

We, on behalf of communities affected by [project], financed by [bank], submit this complaint. The project causes [harm — resettlement without adequate housing or compensation, environmental damage, reduced transboundary flows], in breach of [named safeguards on resettlement, environment, international waterways], including an [outdated/incomplete] assessment and [absent] transboundary consultation. We request an investigation and compliance. We attach documentation, and ask that the safety and confidentiality of affected people be protected, as domestic space is closed.

Respectfully,

[International coalition / representative, contact]

8C: Submission on the Transboundary River

Subject: Transboundary impacts of [project] on the shared [river] basin

To [downstream government / international-water body],

We write regarding [project] on the [Vakhsh/shared river], which feeds the [Amu Darya] on which your nation and millions downstream depend. The project is assessed to [reduce downstream flow / threaten water security] without adequate transboundary consultation, contrary to the international law of shared rivers. We respectfully urge you to raise these concerns with the financiers and through the appropriate international channels, and we can provide hydrological documentation.

Respectfully,

[International coalition / representative, contact]

8D: Report to UNESCO

Subject: Threat to the [Tugay Forests / World Heritage site] from [project]

To the [World Heritage Centre],

We write to report that [project] threatens [the World Heritage floodplain] and its [endangered endemic species] through [flooding / altered flows]. Given the global significance of this site, we respectfully request your attention and engagement with the authorities and financiers. We can provide documentation of the harm to the site's values.

Respectfully,

[International coalition / representative, contact]

8E: Media Pitch (International)

Subject: World's tallest planned dam — mass displacement, a world heritage site, a shared river

Dear [journalist],

[Project] in Tajikistan — planned as the world's tallest dam — would displace tens of thousands, flood the [World Heritage floodplain], and cut the flow of the [shared river] to millions downstream, financed by [banks] under safeguards it may be breaching. There is a major, internationally significant story here, and we can provide documentation and expert voices, while protecting anyone at risk inside the country.

Sincerely,

[International coalition / representative, contact]

8F: Letter to the Financing Banks' Boards

Subject: Concerns ahead of financing decisions on [project]

To the [Board / Executive Directors],

Ahead of decisions on financing [project], we urge you to weigh its documented harms — the displacement of tens of thousands, the threatened World Heritage site, the reduced transboundary flows — and the

[outdated] assessment and [absent] transboundary consultation that appear to breach your own safeguards. We respectfully urge you to require a full, current, independent assessment and genuine transboundary consultation before any further financing. We attach our analysis.

Respectfully,

[International coalition / representative, contact]

8G: Coalition Outreach

Subject: Joining the effort on [project]

Dear [river network / bank watchdog / human-rights-in-development group],

We are working to hold [project] to the safeguards and international-water rules it is bound to, and to carry the concerns of affected communities — who cannot safely speak inside the country — to the financiers, downstream states, and international bodies. Your reach and protection would strengthen the effort. May we coordinate, as the coalitions on this project already have?

In solidarity,

[Representative, contact]

8H: Channelling Affected People's Concerns (Safely)

Subject: Documenting harm — with protection

Dear [trusted coalition / investigator],

Communities affected by [project] wish their concerns to be heard, but cannot safely speak inside the country. We ask your help to document their situation with full protection of their identities and safety, and to carry it to the financiers, the downstream states, and the international bodies. Please advise how testimony can be gathered and transmitted securely, so that no one is exposed to danger.

With care,

[Representative, contact]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a project is moving fast — a financing vote near, a resettlement imminent — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest and safest here, which means the financing decision, a bank complaint, and an international coalition.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials — safely, and largely from abroad: **what the project is, what harm it would do upstream and down, who finances it, and to what safeguards**. Identify the immediate pressure point — a **financing vote, a bank consultation, a resettlement deadline** — because that is what you must affect first. Contact an **international coalition already engaged** — a river network, a bank watchdog — because in Tajikistan an external ally who can act from safer ground is the fastest and safest route to leverage.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **A financing decision** is a fixed moment of maximum leverage — a letter to the board, a demand for a fuller assessment, can land before a vote. **A complaint to a bank's accountability panel** starts an international process. **An alert to downstream states and media** engages the transboundary dimension. **An international coalition's campaign** draws attention repression cannot silence. These external levers are the only ones available — domestic protest is closed and dangerous — and they can move on the timeline of a financing decision.

Emergency Coalition-Building — From Abroad

You cannot build a domestic movement — it is closed and perilous. But you can activate a fast external one: **the international coalitions already engaged, the human-rights investigators, the downstream civil society, and safely-channelled testimony from affected people**. A credible coalition carrying documented harm to a bank's board or panel, at the moment of a financing decision, is the most a rapid Tajik effort can do — and the safest. Speed favours the prepared: know the harm, the safeguards, the financing timeline, the coalition, and the protection of everyone inside before the deadline.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the system is not merely tilted but closed — an authoritarian state, ruled by one man for over three decades, where civil society is rated closed, defenders and journalists are jailed, and the mega-dam is the regime's prestige project. This is Tajikistan's central, honest truth, and the whole guide has been shaped by it. Name it plainly, because pretending the domestic field is contestable would be both false and dangerous.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are the ordinary condition of the state. **Power is concentrated** in a president in office since 1992. **Civil society is closed**, and defenders and journalists are imprisoned. **Transparency is low and corruption high**, by the assessments of those who monitor the country. **The dam is a national prestige project**, decades in the making, that the regime is committed to completing. This is not a tilt a domestic movement can overpower, and open opposition invites imprisonment; it is the closed structure an effort must be built around, which is why this guide places nearly all its weight on the external levers.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the domestic field is closed and dangerous, take the fight entirely to where the project is exposed: **abroad and downstream**. Lean on the **financiers' safeguards and mechanisms**, the **transboundary waters and downstream states**, **UNESCO**, and the **international coalitions** — the levers that reach in from outside and that repression cannot silence. Aim realistically at **safeguard compliance, better resettlement, transboundary consultation, mitigation, delay, and international scrutiny**, rather than at a stop, which the committed regime makes unlikely. Protect people inside by keeping the effort external. And build the record even if the dam proceeds, because a documented breach lodged with the financiers raises the cost and the scrutiny of this project and the next. A closed field here does not so much lengthen the odds as move the fight entirely offshore — and there, at the financiers and the transboundary bodies, the real leverage lies.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may well lose — the dam may be completed — and this guide will not pretend otherwise; the regime is committed, and construction proceeds. If the project advances, the work is still not wasted: the **harm was**

documented, the safeguard breaches lodged with those who can act, the resettlement improved, the transboundary consultation forced, the record made, and the next project — and the slow pressure on financiers to do better — starts stronger. International accountability is incremental; each documented breach raises the bar for the next mega-project. Fight, from safer ground, to hold the dam to its financiers' safeguards and the law of shared rivers; if you lose, lose in a way that leaves an international record, improves the lot of the resettled, and above all keeps people inside safe.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

In Tajikistan, corruption and capture are, by the assessments of those who monitor the country, a serious and real dimension — the state is rated among the most corrupt, with low transparency and concentrated power. This must be approached with great care, because raising it inside the country is dangerous, and the safe and effective route runs, once again, through the international channels.

Telling Capture from Ordinary Tilt

An authoritarian state pursuing a prestige project is tilted; where public money and contracts flow opaquely and enforcement bends to power, it may also be captured. The marks of capture are sharper: **opaque financing and contracts, assessments shaped to approve rather than to assess, enforcement and scrutiny suspended for the powerful, and the silencing of those who ask questions.** Be rigorous and careful: **distinguish an authoritarian prestige project from provable corruption,** and do not level accusations the evidence does not support, especially where doing so endangers people. The international transparency and anti-corruption bodies, and the financiers' own anti-corruption rules, are the safest tools, because they can pursue through established international processes what is deadly to pursue at home.

Responding to Capture — Carefully

Where capture is real, the response is entirely international and pursued from safer ground. Use the **financiers' anti-corruption rules and mechanisms,** which bind the banks and their borrowers, to press documented concerns about the project's finances. Take evidence to **international anti-corruption and investigative bodies and journalists,** who can pursue from abroad what is dangerous at home. Rely on the **transparency the financiers' disclosure requirements compel,** since a bank-financed project must disclose more than a purely domestic one. Document meticulously and protect every source, because in a closed, captured system the evidence is both the weapon and the gravest risk. Route the exposure through international channels — never through any domestic confrontation.

A Note on Safety and Care

This is the guide's most important note, and it governs everything here. Tajikistan jails human-rights defenders and journalists, and its people live in a climate of fear — pursuing any of this from inside carries grave risk to liberty and safety. So keep the effort **external, documentary, coalition-led, and above all protective of everyone inside.** Prefer the financiers' mechanisms, the transboundary bodies, and the international coalitions — all pursued from safer ground — to any domestic action whatsoever. Protect individuals inside absolutely: never expose a name, rely on international and downstream voices and published documentation, and channel any testimony through trusted coalitions that can shield identities. Safety here is not caution at the expense of the cause; it is the first duty of the cause, because no dam contested is worth a person imprisoned, and because the fight can be waged, and is being waged, from safer ground abroad.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others. Here is how they fit into a single, careful, external effort against a destructive mega-project in Tajikistan.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together, carefully and largely from abroad. **Documentation** builds the harm-and-breach file, much of it from already-published sources. **Target identification** aims it at the financiers, the safeguards, and the shared river. **Local opposition** channels affected people's concerns safely through international coalitions and downstream allies. **Legal, regulatory, and international** work presses the financiers' mechanisms, the transboundary bodies, and UNESCO. **Media** carries it to an international audience. The harm and the breach feed all five at once — a documented harm is evidence for a bank complaint, a transboundary submission, a UNESCO report, and an international story together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, where all the strong levers are external, they must reach outward together and safely. The compounding matters especially in Tajikistan, because no single external lever is strong enough to rely on against a committed regime, and the domestic ones are absent. Consider how a single documented harm — the resettlement of a village without adequate housing, say — travels across all the external fronts at once: it is, in the same period, the basis of a complaint to the bank's accountability panel, evidence for a submission on the project's safeguard compliance, a matter for the human-rights investigators' reports, a data point in the international coalition's campaign, and part of the case put to the financing board before a vote. A coalition pursuing only one of these might see it absorbed; one pursuing all of them together makes the harm impossible to ignore across the whole international architecture that finances and governs the project — and does so from safe ground, without exposing anyone inside. In a fight where the domestic space is closed and the external levers are individually modest, this mutual reinforcement across external fronts is the whole strategy.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the project, the harm, the financiers, and the safeguards, largely from published sources; identify the coalitions and the financing timeline. **Middle (months 2–12):** build the external coalition and the case; file with the financiers' mechanism; engage the downstream states, UNESCO, and the transboundary bodies; carry the story to an international audience; and target the financing decisions. **Later (months and years):** press the international processes for safeguard compliance, better resettlement, transboundary consultation, and scrutiny, and build the record whatever the outcome. A Tajik effort is external, patient, and slow, and its likeliest fruit is accountability rather than a stop; pace the effort and one's hopes accordingly — and keep everyone inside safe throughout.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the harm, upstream and down, against the financiers' safeguards and the law of shared rivers; reach the banks' mechanisms, the transboundary bodies, UNESCO, and the international coalitions — the closed state cannot suppress them; protect everyone inside above all; and keep every claim precise.** The coalition that presses all five, safely and from external ground, gives the effort the real but modest chance that a bank-financed transboundary mega-dam allows — to force safeguards, mitigation, better resettlement, transboundary consultation, and scrutiny, and conceivably to delay or reshape the project — while holding, throughout, to the honest truths that a stop is unlikely, domestic opposition is dangerous, and no one has

stopped this dam.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposing a destructive mega-project in Tajikistan is genuinely difficult and, from within, genuinely dangerous — among the very hardest and most dangerous cases in this entire series — and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: there is no community victory, civil society is closed, defenders are jailed, and the regime is committed to its dam. And yet the effort is not futile, because Tajikistan's mega-project answers not only to a closed domestic system but to international development banks bound by safeguards, to the law of shared rivers and the downstream states, to a World Heritage system, and to international coalitions — and those external levers are real, already in use, and far safer than confronting the regime at home.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **The external levers — the financiers' safeguards and panels, the transboundary waters, UNESCO, the international coalitions — are the real ones, and they reach where the closed domestic system and repression cannot follow. A documented breach of binding safeguards and the law of shared rivers is the effort's strongest weapon. But domestic opposition is closed and dangerous, the regime is committed, and the likeliest outcome is accountability or a record, not a stop.** Hold both truths at once: real, external, reachable levers, and honestly closed and hazardous domestic conditions.

Above all, keep the discipline — and the safety — that give these efforts their force. Document the harm, upstream and down, and the broken safeguards. Reach the financiers, the transboundary bodies, UNESCO, and the international coalitions. Protect everyone inside above every other consideration, and keep the fight external. And keep every claim precise, because before a bank's panel and a downstream government, credibility is everything — and for people inside Tajikistan, safety is everything, and more.

The Rogun dam presses ahead — planned as the tallest dam in the entire world, displacing tens of thousands with documented resettlement grievances, threatening a World Heritage floodplain and endangered species, and set to reduce the shared river that millions downstream depend on — its assessment criticised as outdated and incomplete, its own people unable to safely object to any of it. This guide has hidden absolutely none of it. But that same dam is contested, right now, at the international development banks financing it, before the World Bank's Inspection Panel, in the concerns of the downstream states, and by international coalitions carrying affected people's voices from safer ground — because a bank-financed transboundary mega-dam, however immovable at home, is exposed abroad, to safeguards it must meet, to a shared river governed by law, and to a world that is watching. There is, in the end, no easy victory to promise, no community precedent whatsoever to inherit, and no safe path from within; this guide has said so throughout no safe path from within whatsoever; this guide has said so throughout, and insisted on safety above all. But the homes of the resettled, the world heritage floodplain, and the water of millions downstream are worth defending, the financiers' safeguards and the law of shared rivers are real and enforceable from abroad, and the careful, documented, external effort to hold this mega-dam to those standards — pursued safely, and protecting everyone inside — is one worth making. The power here lies offshore, at the banks and the shared river the dam cannot escape. The power here lies offshore, at the banks and the shared river and the watching world that the dam, for all its scale, cannot escape. Reach it carefully, protect your people always and without exception, and you reach the one real leverage this fight truly holds. That leverage is not nothing. A mega-dam that is immovable inside a closed state is, at the same moment, one of the most externally exposed projects imaginable — financed by a consortium of development banks each bound by safeguards and each maintaining an accountability panel,

built on a river shared with three downstream nations and governed by international water law, flooding a site the world has recognised as heritage, and watched by a network of international coalitions that have made it a cause. Every one of those is a handle that can be grasped from safe ground abroad. Grasp them carefully, document meticulously from published and protected sources, shield everyone inside without exception, and press patiently through the financiers and the shared-river bodies, and you will have done, for the resettled and the downstream and the flooded floodplain, the most that can honestly and safely be done — and perhaps have raised the bar for the next mega-dam as well.